

German Declension

<https://www.clozemaster.com/blog/german-adjective-endings/>

You use:

- **Weak declension** for:
 - *alle, beide, diese, jene, manche, sämtliche, solche, welche.*
- **Strong declension** for:
 - *andere, einige, etliche, folgende, mehrere, verschiedene, viele, wenige, zahlreiche.*

<https://germantakeaways.com/german-declension-after-certain-words/>

How do I know when to use the strong or weak ending?

The particularity of the German declension is that the [adjective](#) depends always on **which type of article** we use or if **there is none**.

Adjectives have the **strong** endings (-r, -s, -e, -m, -n) after the

- indefinite (*ein/-e*), negative (*kein/-e*) or possessive (*mein/-e, dein/-e*, etc.) article in nominative (*das ist [k]ein schönes Auto*),
- indefinite (*ein*)/negative (*kein*)/possessive (*mein*) article in accusative feminine (*[k]eine/meine neue Tasse*) and neuter (*[k]ein/mein neues Auto*),
- or without article, also called “zero article” (*er kam mit großem Hunger*, *ich brauche neue Schuhe*).

Adjectives have the **weak** endings (-e, -en) after the

- definite article (*das schöne Auto gehört Hanna*),
- negative (*kein*) and possessive (*mein*) article in plural (*keine/meine neuen Sachen*),
- demonstrative articles *dieser/jener* (this/that),
- interrogative pronoun *welcher* (which),
- pronoun *jeder* (everyone),
- indefinite/negative/possessive article in accusative masculine, dative and genitive (complete).

Special cases

The adjective has also the **strong** (-r, -s, -e, -m, -n) endings after

- the [numeral adjectives](#) *viel/wenig*: *viel/wenig Gutes* (singular), *viele gute Dinge* (plural),
- numerals (*zwei große*), also after genitive/dative *zweier, dreier*, etc. (*zweier großer Häuser*),
- *mehrere*,
- [einiger](#) (masculine singular): *einiger politischer Sinn*; and *einige* (plural): *einige gute Menschen*,
- [etliche\(r/s\)](#): *etlicher politischer Zündstoff*, *etliche gute Menschen*, *die Taten etlicher guter Menschen*.
- [manch](#) (without ending): *manch guter Vorsatz*, *manch gutes Buch*.

The adjective has also the **weak** (-e, -en) ending after the

- indefinite pronoun [alle\(r/s\)](#) (singular)/*alle* (plural): (nom./acc. sing.) *alles Gute*, (nom./acc. plur.) *alle guten Übungen*, (genitive) *alles/allen (neuen) Lebens*
- indefinite pronoun [manche\(r/s\)](#) (some): *mancher gute Vorsatz* (in plural, also the strong ending is possible: *manche ältere Leute*),
- indefinite pronoun [solche\(r/s\)](#) (such): *solcher feine Stoff* (in plural, also the strong ending is possible: *solche gute Menschen*),
- indefinite pronoun and numeral [beide](#) (both): *beide großen Gemeinschaften* (but **with** article: *die beiden großen Gemeinschaften*),
- *einiges* (neuter singular): *einiges alte* (rare: *altes*) *Gerümpel*.

Declension after personal pronouns

According to [Duden](#), both options are possible after a personal pronoun depending on if an adjective follows or not.

- weak ending (with adjective): *wir bescheidenen Leute*; *wir Armen*; *wir Erwachsenen*; *wir Deutschen* (obsolete: *wir Deutsche*); *ihr geliebten Berge!*; *ihr Lieben/ihr beiden* (also: *ihr beide*), *wir/ihr beiden jungen Leute*
- strong ending: *wir alle*, *wir/sie/Sie beide* (rare: *wir beiden*), (genitive:) *unser/euer/ihrer beider*

<https://germanwithlaura.com/declension/>

Special Situations

The All-In-One Declensions Chart *can* feel a little complicated until you get the hang of it, I know.

Trust me: learning how to work with it will still save you heaps of time and energy compared to working with *ten* different charts!

There are several last things you need to learn about in order to use the All-In-One Declensions Chart like a master:

1. Nouns themselves that take declensions
2. Zero Words (special determiners that don't *ever* take declensions!)
3. Certain words that have multiple functions
4. A special rule-breaking declensions pattern used with plural nouns
5. The word '*all*' is a bit in a class all its own.

Special Situation #1: Declined Nouns

Dative plural nouns

ALL plural nouns in the dative case add an -n to the end of them IF there's not one there already OR unless the plural form is -s (e.g. with foreign nouns):

nominative plural: *die Kinder* (the children) → dative plural: *den Kindern*

BUT

nominative plural: *die Wagen* (the cars) → dative plural: *den Wagen*

nominative plural: *die Autos* (also 'the cars') → dative plural: *den Autos*

[Here's another example with a dative plural noun.](#)

Masculine & neuter nouns in the genitive case

[In the genitive case only, masculine & neuter nouns take an 's' or 'es' at the end of them:](#)

des Vaters, des Kindes.

'Weak' masculine nouns

There is no good reason *why* the terminology is 'weak' masculine nouns, but anyway, here is how it works:

There is a group of masculine nouns that take an -en declension in every case *except* in the nominative, for example:

nominative: *der Student*

accusative: *den Studenten* (<- singular! compare with **die Studenten**, plural!)

dative: *dem Studenten* (<- singular! compare with **den Studenten**, plural!)

genitive: *des Studenten* (<- note: NO extra -(e)s for these 'weak' nouns in the genitive!*)

Most of the 'weak' masculine nouns refer to male people or animals. Notice that many nouns end with -e OR with a suffix of foreign origin (e.g. -arch, -ist, -om):

der Bauer (farmer)

der Affe (monkey)

der Löwe (lion)

der Experte (expert)

der Junge (boy)

der Kunde (customer)

der Nachbar (neighbor)

der Russe (Russian)

der Jude (Jew)

der Monarch (monarch)

der Komponist (composer)

der Astronom (astronomer)

Mensch (person)

Bär (bear)

Christ (male Christian)

Herr (sir)

Elefant (elephant)

Bauer (farmer)

Held (hero)

NOTE: Other less common examples include *Prinz* (prince), *Narr* (fool), *Ochs* (ox), *Fink* (finch), *Spatz* (sparrow), *Pfau* (peacock).

Of course, all of those nouns ^^ would have female variants, too; but those do not apply to our special situation! ([Read more on female noun variants](#)).

*There is a short list of 'weak' masculine nouns that add the -n and THEN an -s in the genitive, as per regular rules:

der Buchstabe (letter of the alphabet)

der Friede (peace)

der Funke (spark)

der Gedanke (thought)

der Glaub (belief)

der Name (name)

der Same (seed)

der Wille (will)

There is even ONE neuter noun that is semi-‘weak’: *das Herz* (nom) → *das Herz* (acc) → *dem Herzen* (dat) → *des Herzens* (gen)

Notes:

- ‘weak’ masculine nouns do NOT decline if they are used without a determiner, e.g. *Das Problem war für Arzt und Patient verblüffend* (The problem was puzzling to [both the] doctor and [the] patient).
- of course, in *colloquial* German, many ‘weak’ masculine nouns are treated as totally normal nouns (i.e. not declined), e.g. *der Student* → *den Student* → *dem Student* → *des Students*.

Special Situation #2: Zero Words

ZERO WORDS: a special set of determiners that takes *zero* (i.e. no) declensions, no matter where in the chart they are used.

Think of the three special instances on our Chart where there is a  listed.

That symbol reminds us that specifically *ein-word determiners* will take no declensions in those spots (masculine nominative, neuter nominative, neuter accusative) and that *adjectives* (if present) will take the strong declension.

Well, now just imagine that you can use a *zero word anywhere* in the Chart and it functions the same way:

RULE: If using a *zero word* (which takes *no declension*), any following adjectives take *strong declensions*.

There are a few **strictly** *Zero Words* used with singular nouns:

ein bisschen / ein wenig (a little)

etwas (some)

nichts (nothing)

genug (enough)

lauter (only, nothing but)

dergleichen / derlei (suchlike, that kind / sort of)

And a **strictly** *Zero Word* used with plural nouns:

ein paar (a couple of, a few)

Examples:

Bitte schenk mir etwas heißes Wasser ein! (Please pour me [into my cup] a little hot water!).

Auf genug Zeit kommt es nicht dran (It doesn't have anything to do with having enough time).

Ein paar fleißige Studenten meldeten sich (A couple hard-working students raised their hands).

There are *some* determiners that function as *zero words* in the singular, but as determiners (that *do* take declensions!) in the plural, which leads straight into our next special situation:

Special Situation #3: Words With Multiple Functions

There is a large body of German words that can function differently — sometimes as a determiner / pronoun, other times as an adjective, or as a *zero word* (always in the singular except for *all-* which can be a zero word in the singular OR plural → keep reading!).

Of course, the *role* of the word in the given phrase impacts *which declension* (if any) *it must take!*

Determiner / Zero Word

As you can see in the following huge table, here are several words that function as *zero words* in the singular AND as determiners in the plural:

wenig(-) (a little)

viel(-) (a lot)

manch(-) (many)

solch(-) (such)

all(-) (all)*

*Also functions as a *zero word* in the *plural* (See below for more).

Multi-Use German Words

German with Laura

	zero word	plural determiner	adjective	pronoun
*wenig(-)				
*viel(-)				
solch(-)				
all(-)	1			2
*manch(-)				
*etlich-				
*ander-				
*mehrer-				
beid-				
sämtlich-				
ein(-)				
*einig-				2
*verschieden-				
*zahlreich-				
*folgend-				



= Can use



= Can't use

* Use adjectives with **strong** declensions after these determiners

¹ all(-) can be used as a zero word in both the singular & plural

² In the singular, use neuter declensions, e.g.: alles, einiges

NOTE: Zero Words (used in the singular only) take no declension. Following modifier takes strong declension.

TABLE CORRECTION: 'Zero Words' used in the singular are followed by modifiers taking the strong declension *except* that *solch-* and *manch-* may be followed by an *ein-*word, which must follow our regular rules regarding declension pattern #1 vs. #2.

So, for example, one would say 'Solch ein Fehler wird nie wieder vorkommen.' (declension pattern #2) but 'Solch eine Überraschung kommt nicht oft vor!' (declension pattern #1).

Likewise, one would say 'Manch ein Mann versteht das nicht,' but 'Manch eine Frau versteht das nicht.'

Here are a few examples of these words functioning as *zero words*:

Mit wenig öder Arbeit kannst du ...

(You can ... with [just a] little tedious work).

Viel flauschiger Schnee liegt auf dem Dach

(A lot of fluffy snow lay on top of the roof).

Solch ein Fehler wird nicht wieder vorkommen.

(Such a mistake won't happen again!).

And here are some similar examples, but with the words functioning as plural determiners:

Wenige Arbeiter werden gebraucht.

(Few workers are needed).

Viele Schneestürme werden übers Wochenende erwartet.

(Many snowstorms are expected over the weekend).

Solche Fehler mache ich immer wieder!

(I'm repeatedly making such mistakes [as these]!)

Determiners / Pronouns

Notice that anything listed in the table as a determiner is *also* a pronoun!

Determiners / Pronouns will all take *strong declensions* as per our standard rules & basic declension pattern #1 that follows from them.

Determiners vs. Pronouns is a worthy distinction in that they each play a *different grammatical role* in a given sentence.

For example:

Determiner: *Solche Schuhe finde ich ganz schön* (I think shoes such as these are really lovely).

Pronoun: *Welche Schuhe möchtest du? –Solche!* (Which shoes do you want? –Ones like these!)

BUT! Determiners vs. Pronouns take *the same declensions* (like you can see in the above examples ^^) except in a handful of special instances (covered soon).

So, for our purposes (<– since we’re not linguists), we don’t really care about the technical distinction. We care about the functional sameness!

The ONLY time the determiners vs. pronouns distinction matters is with *ein-words*: *ein*, *kein*, *irgendein*, and all of the *possessives*.

Ein-words used as *determiners* decline using our special 3 *no declension instances* listed in our All-In-One Chart:

All-In-One German Declensions Chart Articles • Other Determiners • Adjective Endings										
 no declension  strong declension  weak declension										
		Masc.		Fem.		Neut.		Plural		
										
Nom.		r	e	e	e		s	e	e	n
Acc.		n	n	e	e		s	e	e	n
Dat.		m	n	r	n		m	n	n	n
Gen.		s	n	r	n		s	n	r	n

But ein-words used as *pronouns* will use ALL the regular, strong declensions — no exceptions!

Example:

Determiner: *Einen* blauen Rock hätte ich gerne! (I’d like a blue skirt)

Pronoun: So *einen*! [points to a blue skirt] (One [replacing ‘a blue skirt’] like this!).

Determiner / Adjective

You can see the in massive table that there are also many words that can function as *either* a plural determiner *or* as an adjective (in front of a plural noun).

NOTE: the determiner *ein* is our only exception case: it is a *singular*, not plural, determiner; as an adjective, it works like this: *Das eine Buch, das ich dieses Jahr gelesen habe ...* (The one book I read this year ...)

- A plural determiner or a stand-alone (declensions pattern #2) adjective would take the *strong* declension.
- BUT! If the adjective *follows a determiner* (declensions pattern #1), it will need a *weak* declension!

Examples:

Viele Studenten rauchen

(Many students smoke).

Die vielen Studenten die rauchen....

(The many students who smoke ...)

Special Situation #4: Plural Determiners

When we deal with *singular* nouns, we have to split determiners into 2 groups: *ein-words* and *der-words* (remember: this distinction matters only in our 3 exception spots — the rest of the time, a determiner is just a determiner!).

In the plural, we still have two distinct categories of determiners: one that always follows the rules (like *der-words*) and one that is all about exceptions (like *ein-words*). ← For more discussion on this point, read my study tips below.

RULE: Regular Determiners take strong declensions. Any following adjective(s) take weak.

Regular Determiners:

All- (all [covered in depth below!])

Welch- (which)

Irgendwelch- (any)

Die/ Der (the)

Solch- (such)

Beid- (both)

Sämtlich- ('each and every' → more defineable than 'all')

Kein- (no, not any)

Possessives (e.g. my, your, etc.)

Now, did you notice some words in that huge table that have an * in front of them? Here, look again:

Multi-Use German Words

German with Laura

	zero word	plural determiner	adjective	pronoun
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*viel(-)				
solch(-)				
all(-)	1			2
*manch(-)				
*etlich-				
*ander-				
*mehrer-				
beid-				
sämtlich-				
ein(-)				
*einig-				2
*verschieden-				
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* Use adjectives with **strong** declensions after these determiners

¹ all(-) can be used as a zero word in both the singular & plural

² In the singular, use neuter declensions, e.g.: alles, einiges

NOTE: Zero Words (used in the singular only) take no declension. Following modifier takes strong declension.

Those * in the table mark the *rulebreaking* plural determiners!

RULE: Rulebreaker Determiners *also* take strong declensions (as per normal) BUT they require that any following adjective(s) take strong declensions, too (<– which is weird).

Example: *Einige amerikanische* (NOT *einige amerikanischeN*) *Studenten lernen Deutsch* (Some American students learn German).

In contrast to the regular determiners that are similar to the concept of *der-words*, these rulebreakers are akin to *ein-words*: they are *indefinite*, or, in other words, more vague.

Rulebreaker Determiners:

etlich- (quite a lot of)

verschieden- (various, different)

zahlreich- (numerous)

folgend- (following)

manch- (some, many)

wenig- (few)

ander- (other, different)

einig- (some)

mehrer- (multiple)

viel- (a lot of)

TIP: Because the plural dative strong & weak declensions are identical, you don't in that instance have to worry about if a determiner is regular or a rulebreaker — it doesn't make a difference.

Special Situation #5: all-

Like all *zero words* in the table, *all-* can function also function as a regular determiner / pronoun.

What's weird about its *zero word* status, though, is that *all-* can be used as a *zero word* in the singular *or* in the plural.

Zero Word Examples:

In the singular:

All das schlechte Wetter macht mir schlechte Laune!

Notice: *all-*, of course, has no declension. The determiner takes the strong declension and the adjective the weak one listed for the neuter nominative and as per declension pattern #1.

In the plural (note the optional 'e'):

All(e) unaufrichtige Angebote lehne ich ab (I reject all insincere offers).

Notice: the adjective *unaufrichtig*- has the strong plural accusative declension!

All as a regular determiner (in the plural ONLY):

Der Freundschaftsbruch [plural nominative] *hat alle guten Erinnerungen vernichtet* (The breakup of the friendship destroyed all the good memories).

Notice the strong declension on *all*- and the weak one on *gut*-!